UPFRONT

NISAR SATELLITE: THE PLANET MAPPER *PG 10*

VIEWPOINT: PUTTING AN END TO HEPATITIS B *PG 12*

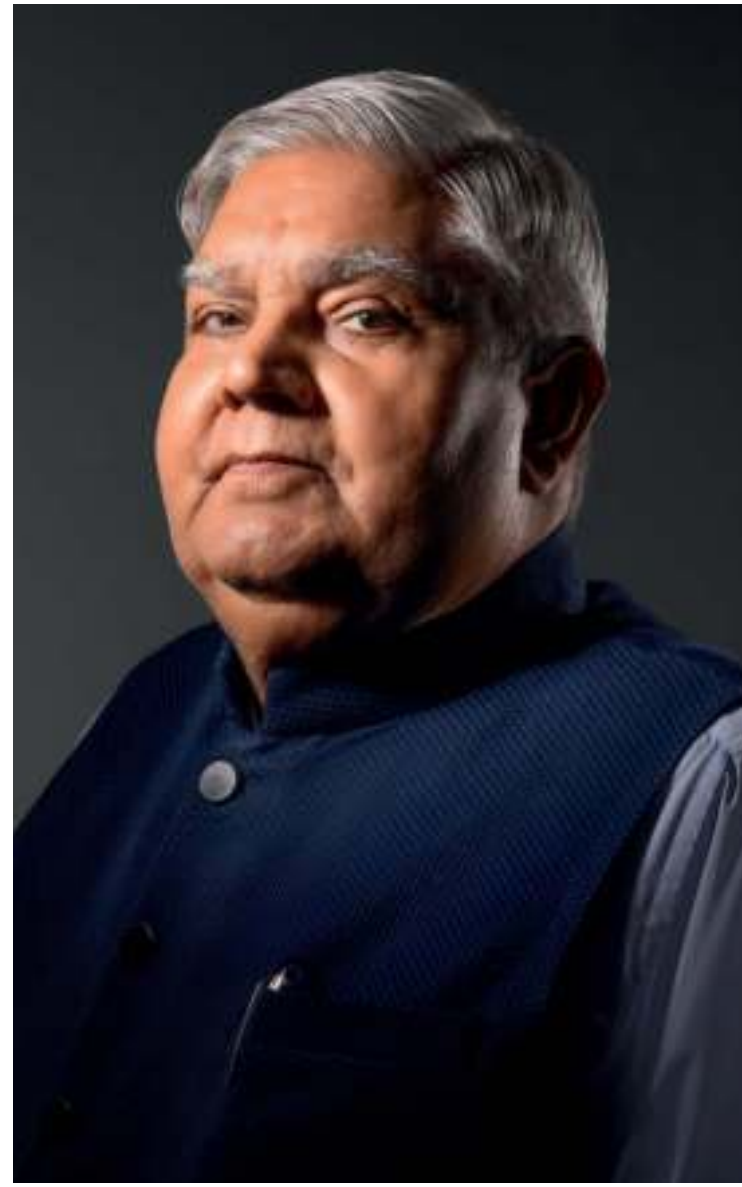
▶ JAGDEEP DHANKHAR

DHANKHAR DHAMAKA

An impeachment motion against a judge, purported internal dissent and power play force the Vice-President out

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN & KAUSHIK DEKA

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**



IN INDIA'S POLITICAL HISTORY, few resignations have generated as much intrigue and speculation as Jagdeep Dhankhar's sudden departure from vice-presidency on the night of July 21. While the 74-year-old cited health concerns in his letter to President Droupadi Murmu, none in New Delhi's high-stakes political theatre is buying the excuse.

Yes, Dhankhar had fainted once at a public event earlier this year. He also visited AIIMS for cardiac care and angioplasty. But if health genuinely was the overriding concern, conventional wisdom suggests Dhankhar would have chosen to step down before the commencement of Parliament's monsoon session, allowing for a smooth transition. Instead, he chose the most disruptive possible moment: the session's opening day, when the Upper House he chaired was set to tackle contentious issues, including Operation Sindoor and the controversial Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls in Bihar. This timing transformed what could have been a dignified exit into a political earthquake.

The events of July 21 offer a fascinating study in how swiftly political fortunes can turn in Lutyens' Delhi. Dhankhar began his day with characteristic vigour, presiding over proceedings in the Rajya Sabha. Most tellingly, at 4 pm, the Vice-President's office released his official schedule for the coming days, including a planned visit to Jaipur on July 23. At 9:25 pm, out of the blue, his resignation was public on X. Something, clearly, snapped between those hours.

Multiple sources point to a cascade of events before and during these crucial hours that fundamentally altered the political equation. Dhankhar's sudden, unscheduled visit to Rashtrapati Bhavan around 9 pm and his very public exit from the stage just 25 minutes later point to a decision made under immediate pressure rather than careful deliberation.